

Varya Stepanova

Design Systems & AI Engineer

linkedin.com/in/varyastepanova | varya.me/projects-portfolio

+358 50 57 50 907 mail@varya.me Espoo, Finland (remotely — EMEA)

PROFILE

Design systems and AI engineer with 20+ years building component systems, design token architectures, and the AI-assisted workflows that ship them faster. Hands-on across React, TypeScript, Web Components, and Next.js: from Figma flows and design tokens to released UI features, with strong taste for accessibility, pixel-level polish, and how things feel. Framework agnostic by practice (React, Web Components on Lit, React Native), not just principle. AI/agentic engineering is daily craft: building custom Claude skills, Cursor agents, MCP servers, and RAG pipelines for component development, spec-to-code workflows, and design-system adoption on legacy codebases. Ran a design-system consultancy for 6 years, slotting into client engineering teams for long-term engagements (up to 2.5 years) and shipping production systems adopted by 100–200 developers per organization. Created and facilitated AI-assisted design and development workshops training 120+ designers and engineers. In the past: core team member of BEM methodology, pioneered internationally as an industry-standard CSS architecture approach.

[Design System Portfolio: varya.me/projects-portfolio](https://varya.me/projects-portfolio)

SKILLS

- Design Systems & Component Libraries (React, Web Components, React Native)
- AI/Agentic Engineering (Cursor, Claude Code, custom MCP servers, RAG, context engineering)
- Design Tokens & Theming Architecture
- Figma & Design-Engineering Collaboration
- Framework-Agnostic Component Architecture (Lit, React, CSS-only outputs)
- Accessibility (WCAG), UI Performance & Visual Regression
- Storybook Customization, CI/CD & GitHub Actions
- Full-stack Development (Next.js, PostgreSQL, tRPC, Node.js)
- Technical Architecture & Project Management
- Workshop Facilitation & Developer Education

EDUCATION

Master of Computer Science

Aalto University, IDBM
2017 - 2021

Master of Physics

Petrozavodsk State University
2000 - 2007

LANGUAGES

English (fluent)

Finnish (advanced)

Russian (native)

WORK EXPERIENCE

► Design Systems & AI Engineer / Founder / Sep 2019 – Present

Bridge the Gap, Helsinki, Finland

Founded a design-system consultancy operating at the intersection of design and engineering, growing the team from 1 to 5 engineers. Operated as senior IC and player-coach on long-term client engagements (up to 2.5 years): architecting component libraries, partnering daily with designers in Figma, shipping production UI end-to-end, and introducing AI-assisted workflows for faster, design-faithful delivery. Served 6 clients including ManyChat, Yara International, AppOmni, Elisa, KnowLA, and F-Secure, with UI systems adopted by 100–200 developers across client organizations. Agency model built for exactly this: slotting into an existing team, ramping fast, and shipping production-quality design system work from week one.

- Shipped 100+ production-ready components (React, React Native, Web Components on Lit) across client projects with 100% accessibility compliance and automated visual regression testing. At ManyChat (17-month engagement), delivered 25+ composable React components with a scalable form-element foundation, grew DS adoption from ~20% to ~80% on key product views, and owned adoption end-to-end (~1,500 product file-touches by the DS team)
- Built a framework-agnostic Web Components library at AppOmni (Lit, CSS custom properties, Style Dictionary tokens from Figma, Storybook auto-docs from JSDoc): 25 published components, 63 releases in nine months. Validated cross-framework compatibility with a separate Vue harness application proving real consumer-context portability

- Architected design token systems spanning web and mobile at Yara International (React + React Native, NX monorepo, distributed 6-country team): three-tier token vocabulary (Global / Semantic / Component) with one source emitting Figma + JavaScript + SCSS, dark mode as a semantic-layer swap rather than a catalogue fork
- AI/agent engineering is the dominant shape of daily work: building custom Claude skills, Cursor agents, and MCP servers for component generation, spec-to-code workflows, and Storybook automation. Built and published a custom MCP + RAG system (Postgres + pgvector) that hands AI agents prepared adoption examples from past diffs, replacing expensive exploration on legacy codebases with retrieval
- Created and facilitated hands-on workshops on AI-assisted design and development (Cursor, MCPs, RAG, agentic specs, Figma-to-Storybook AI workflows): trained 120+ designers and engineers across enterprise and public-facing programs, including 80 designers specifically on Cursor + Figma workflows

➤ **Product Owner for Design System** / *July 2021 – September 2023*

METRO digital, Düsseldorf, Germany (remote)

Worked on a multi-library design system used across 20+ product teams in 20+ applications at METRO digital (technology arm of METRO AG, one of Europe's largest B2B wholesale eCommerce groups). Owned component architecture and design-engineering collaboration end-to-end: paired daily with designers on Figma flows, tokens, and component APIs; shipped production React + Web Components used company-wide. Worked across the full UI ecosystem: React component library, Web Components library, design libraries (Sketch and Figma), dedicated Storybooks, design tokens, and a Zeroheight documentation website.

- Shipped React and Web Components, enabling cohesive theming across 20+ product applications; drove total unique DS imports up by 35% every six months through phased adoption and design-engineering pairing
- Practised scanning product codebases to track component imports, giving the DS team hard data on adoption per team; OKR framework with DORA metrics, CSAT surveys (grew to 80%+), and live cost-savings dashboards translating DS adoption into financial impact per product
- Grew team from 1 engineer / 1 designer to 5 engineers / 2 designers; managed full hiring, onboarding, and performance review cycle across a distributed team in 3 countries
- Operated a hybrid governance model: centralized core with a structured contribution path for product teams, enabling inner-source design and engineering collaboration

➤ **Design System Specialist** / *October 2014 – March 2019*

Nordcloud/SC5, Helsinki, Finland

Delivered frontend systems and design-system solutions across client digital products at a digital agency. Maintained and popularized **SC5 Styleguide** (1,000+ GitHub stars), an open-source docs-as-code generator for component documentation. Led Elisa Design System v1 (2017–2018): delivered React and HTML/CSS component libraries, Sketch UI kit, and an in-house InnerSource model for DS maintenance across product teams.

➤ **Lead Frontend Developer** / *September 2013 – April 2014*

TMG (De Telegraaf Media Groep), Amsterdam, Netherlands

Built frontend solutions for TMG's high-traffic digital media products. Introduced component-based frontend architecture, contributed to REST API design from the consumer side, and fostered knowledge sharing across the team.

➤ **Team lead for UI Framework** / *June 2008 – August 2013*

Yandex, Moscow, Russia

Hands-on senior engineer on an internal UI framework with 150+ components for Europe's largest internet company, serving 300–500 developers across 80+ services. Core team member of **BEM methodology**: pioneered and popularized BEM internationally across Europe, India, and the United States through conference talks, publications, and documentation.

HIGHLIGHTS

- Built AI-assisted design and engineering workflows as daily craft (custom Claude skills, Cursor agents, MCP servers, RAG pipelines) and trained 120+ designers and engineers on these practices through public and enterprise workshops, including a custom MCP + RAG system for design-system adoption on legacy codebases
- Shipped 100+ production-ready components across React, React Native, and Web Components (framework agnostic by practice) with 100% accessibility compliance, automated visual regression, and design token architectures spanning web and mobile platforms across 6 client engagements
- Drove design system adoption +35% every six months at METRO digital across 20+ product teams through phased migration strategy, data-driven metrics (DORA, CSAT, codebase-scan tracking), and design-engineering pairing with consumer teams